THE WATERS HAVE STARTED TO RECEDE BACK INTO THE RAVI, but life in Gurchak village, in the Dera Baba Nanak area of Gurdaspur district, Punjab, will take months to return to normal. The village's 650 acres of farmland remain fully submerged, while another 1,100 acres are heavy with murky pools and silt from the monstrous surge on August 27. That afternoon, minutes after the floodgates at the Madhopur barrage near Pathankot were breached, the rampaging Ravi tore through temporary embankments, transforming what were once lush green fields into scenes of devastation. By the end of the day, the river had swollen 3-4 km on both sides. Two weeks later, the air here is still dank with the stench of rotting crops and dead livestock. Gurchak is emblematic of Punjab's monsoon ordeal this year. Across the state, around 1,900 villages were inundated, 56 people died, and some 480,000 acres of farmland have gone under.

If Punjab's tragedy is about the drowned countryside, in Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Jammu & Kashmir, it's about the mountains crumbling and river valleys inundated. Indeed, this monsoon season, northwest India has seen the worst of the whiplash fury of the rains. According to data from the India Meteorological Department (IMD), 124 of the 208 districts in the region, or nearly 60 per cent, received excess/ large rainfall in the June 1-September 1 period. The stats are mind-boggling: while Punjab got in excess of 612 mm of aggregate rain (50 per cent above normal compared to an average monsoon), the figure was close to 1,000 mm for Himachal, climbing up to 1,342 mm for Uttarakhand. J&K had no better news to tell, with 37 per cent excess rain, and reel highlights featuring an August 26 cloudburst that saw 380 mm of rain fall in a 24-hour period that almost, literally, sunk Jammu. It was clear that climate change was playing havoc in the region, with devastating effect. What was also evident was how poorly these states were prepared for the deluge and its consequences, as this ground report indicates.



PTI

IMD DATA SAYS THAT OF THE 208 DISTRICTS IN NORTHWEST INDIA, NEARLY 60% RECEIVED EXCESS/ LARGE RAINFALL IN THE JUNE 1 TO SEPT. 1 PERIOD

PUNJAB'S DAM MISERIES

In April, when the IMD predicted 105 per cent of normal rainfall during the monsoon, the Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB)—which manages the Bhakra Nangal dam on the Sutlej and the others on the Beas—had recommended controlled releases from Bhakra to prevent reservoir overflow. But Punjab opposed it, citing state allocation norms and even deployed police at the dam to block